# Chapter 17 – The British Raj

"Praise to our Indian brothers, and the dark face have his due!
Thanks to the kindly dark faces who fought with us, faithful and few,
Fought with the bravest among us, and drove them, and smote them, and slew.
That ever upon the topment roof our banner in India blew."
(Alfred Tennyson)

Fort St. George became Madras, and later Chennai, and it was here the British centered their colonial rule over India. British soldiers had already been imported to help the trading company deal with competition from other European traders, so all that was left was to keep expanding westward until the East India Company had authority over a wide ribbon of land that stretched from the southernmost point of India to the easternmost point at Plassey, then back west along the northern border. By the mid-19th century, Britain was effectively in control of the majority of the subcontinent. The original royal charter that funded the continued Company Rule over Indian lands had expired, however, and was only guaranteed 20 years extension at a time.

The British Crown and its government had been imposing more and more on the sovereignty of the East India Company with each renewed contract, and when the locals revolted in 1857, Queen Victoria had the charter canceled altogether. In Parliament, the Government of India Act of 1858 was passed, which stipulated that the EIC be liquidated and all its assets and lands handed over to the British Crown.

The rebellion had begun in May of 1857 when Indian members of the Company Army mutinied in several cities. At odds with their colonial superiors over land taxes, social reforms, and racial discrimination, the sepoys—as these soldiers were called—incited a violent rebellion in which they broke from the EIC and tried to declare themselves a sovereign nation within the company's lands. To this end, rebels met with the last ruler of the Mughals, Bahadur Shah Zafar, and named him as their emperor. They captured large sections in the northwest and held many of the cities there for nearly two years before the EIC regained control through violent, sometimes cruel, warfare.